



Theme: The Word Became Flesh

Quote for Reflection: "The Word became flesh and tabernacled among us—God didn't visit, He moved into the neighborhood." — Project 3|26



Overview

John 1 is the theological foundation of the Gospel. John doesn't start with Jesus' birth—he starts before creation with the eternal Word who was with God and was God. Then comes the incarnation: "The Word became flesh and dwelt among us" (v. 14). The Greek *eskēnōsen* means "tabernacled"—Jesus is the new Tabernacle where God's presence dwells. Your group will explore Jesus as eternal God who became human, the Light invading darkness, and the Lamb who takes away sin.



Group Flow Guide

Section	Time	Purpose
Icebreaker	10 min	Build connection
Scripture & Summary	10 min	Focus the group
Guided Discussion	35-40 min	Go deeper
Group Reflection	10 min	Apply the Word

Icebreaker Options

1. **Before the Beginning:** "What's something you wish you could have been there for 'in the beginning'?"
 2. **Light in Darkness:** "When have you experienced darkness, and what brought light?"
 3. **Recognizing Voices:** "Whose voice do you recognize instantly? What makes it distinct?"
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Leader Prep

Historical Context: John writes decades after the other Gospels—going deeper theologically. "Word" (Logos) = God's creative power. John says this Word is Jesus, who "became flesh and tabernacled among us" (v. 14). In Exodus, God's glory filled the Tabernacle. Now God's glory dwells in human flesh.

Theological Themes: Incarnation (God became man); Light vs. Darkness (cosmic conflict); Belief and Reception (receive Jesus = become God's children); Tabernacle fulfilled (Jesus is where heaven meets earth).

Anticipate These Questions: *Why start before creation?* (Show Jesus is eternal God). *What does "Word became flesh" mean?* (Incarnation—God took human nature). *How do we "receive" Jesus?* (Trust and obedience, not just intellectual assent).

Group Dynamic Tips: This is theologically dense. Ground abstract concepts in application: "What difference does it make that Jesus is God in flesh?" Celebrate simple faith—you don't need to understand everything.

Discussion Questions

Text-Based Questions

Q1: What does "In the beginning was the Word" (v. 1) tell us about Jesus? *Leader Note:* Jesus existed before creation—He's eternal. "Was" = continuous past tense. He didn't start at Bethlehem. This destroys any view of Jesus as just a man or created being.

Q2: How does verse 14 describe where Jesus "dwelt" and why does that matter? *Leader Note:* *Eskēnōsen* = "tabernacled." In Exodus 40, God's glory filled the Tabernacle. Now God's glory takes flesh. Jesus is the new Tabernacle—the meeting place between God and humanity. He relocated.

Q3: What does "Lamb of God who takes away sin" (v. 29) reveal about Jesus' mission? *Leader Note:* Jesus is the sacrificial Lamb. Exodus 12: lambs died so Israel lived (Passover). Isaiah 53: Suffering Servant led to slaughter. Jesus is the final Lamb whose death takes away sin globally.

Q4: How do verses 11-12 describe two responses to Jesus? *Leader Note:* Rejection: "His own did not receive Him" (v. 11). Reception: "As many as received Him...become children of God" (v. 12). You either receive or reject. Reception grants adoption.

Q5: What does verse 13 say about how people are born into God's family? *Leader Note:* "Not of blood nor will of flesh nor will of man, but of God." You're not born into God's family by descent, effort, or decision. God births you spiritually when you believe.

Interpretive Questions

Q1: What's the significance of Jesus being called "the Word" (Logos)? *Leader Note:* Genesis 1: God spoke, creation happened. Logos = God's creative power. John says this Word is Jesus—agent of creation, revealer of God. When you see Jesus, you see what God is saying.

Q2: How does tabernacle imagery connect to Scripture? *Leader Note:* Exodus 40: God's glory filled Tabernacle. 1 Kings 8: filled Temple. John 1: dwells in Jesus. Jesus is new temple—where heaven meets earth. We don't need buildings—we need Jesus.

Q3: Why does John emphasize darkness "did not comprehend" the Light (v. 5)? *Leader Note:* Can mean "understand" and "overcome." Darkness didn't understand (spiritual blindness) and couldn't overcome (Jesus wins). Sets up cosmic conflict: Light vs. Darkness.

Q4: What does "born of God" (v. 13) mean? *Leader Note:* Spiritual birth—regeneration. Physical birth gives physical life; spiritual birth gives spiritual life. You can't birth yourself spiritually. God does it when you believe.

Q5: How does John 1 set the stage for the Gospel? *Leader Note:* John 1 = thesis; rest = proof. Jesus is eternal Word (deity), became flesh (incarnation), is Light (revelation), is Lamb (atonement), offers life to believers (salvation).

♥ Application & Reflection Questions

Q1: Have you received Jesus, or just acknowledged His existence? *Leader Note:* Many know about Jesus without knowing Him. Receiving isn't intellectual assent—it's trust and surrender. Challenge: Move from acknowledging to receiving.

Q2: What difference does it make that Jesus is eternal God who became flesh? *Leader Note:* If Jesus is just a man, His death is tragic not redemptive. If God in flesh, His death atones and resurrection defeats death. How does this change how you approach Him?

Q3: Where do you need to remember God didn't just visit—He moved in permanently? *Leader Note:* We treat God like a distant deity. Jesus tabernacled—He's Immanuel, "God with us." Where do you live like God is distant when He's near?

Q4: Are you living in darkness or have you been born again by God? *Leader Note:* You're either in darkness or light. If born again, you see Jesus clearly. If still in darkness, Jesus seems foolish. Do you see Him as Light?

Q5: When Jesus says "Come and see" (v. 39), are you following or standing at distance? *Leader Note:* Andrew and John spent the day with Jesus—everything changed. You can analyze from a distance or spend time and be transformed. What would that look like this week?

Reflection Prompt

If someone asked "Who is Jesus?" based only on John 1, what would you say?

Prayer Guide

Invite everyone to name one way John 1 has challenged or encouraged them.

Sample Prayer: "Father, thank You the Word became flesh and tabernacled among us. Thank You Jesus is eternal God who moved into the neighborhood. Help us receive Him, not just acknowledge Him. Teach us to follow when He says 'Come and see.' Make us people born of God, not just flesh. Through Christ, Amen."